

Cybersecurity English Jargon Quick Reference

Field-specific terms, contrast pairs, and high-pressure sentence frames

Audience: security analysts, SOC staff, incident responders, security engineers, GRC specialists, identity teams, vulnerability managers, and security leaders

Focus: A cybersecurity English curriculum for incident response, vulnerability triage, identity, threat modeling, risk communication, compliance, executive briefings, and security pushback.

Designed for advanced ESL learners who already use professional English and need industry-specific terminology, realistic meetings, role-play pressure, careful pushback, and polished workplace outputs.

Teaching stance: this is language and workplace-communication training, not legal, medical, financial, safety, or regulatory advice. Instructors should connect every scenario to the learner's current company policies, local rules, and approved procedures.

Nomenclature and Jargon

These are classroom working definitions. Learners should adapt wording to their organization's policies, systems, and local regulatory environment.

Security Triage and Alert Investigation

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
SIEM	In cybersecurity, SIEM is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to move from noisy alerts to risk-based investigation.	clarify SIEM; document SIEM	Contrast: SIEM should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify SIEM and the evidence that supports it.
alert	In cybersecurity, alert is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to move from noisy alerts to risk-based investigation.	clarify alert; document alert	Contrast: alert should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify alert and the evidence that supports it.
false positive	In cybersecurity, false positive is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to move from noisy alerts to risk-based investigation.	clarify false positive; document false positive	Contrast: false positive should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify false positive and the evidence that supports it.
privileged account	In cybersecurity, privileged account is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to move from noisy alerts to risk-based investigation.	clarify privileged account; document privileged account	Contrast: privileged account should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify privileged account and the evidence that supports it.

Incident Response and Containment

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
incident	Unplanned event that disrupts service, safety, quality, security, operations, or expected performance.	assess incident; mitigate incident	Contrast: incident identifies a possible or current exposure; it is not the same as accepting that exposure. Example: We need to assess incident, name the owner, and agree on the trigger for escalation.
containment	In cybersecurity, containment is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to communicate urgency without speculation.	clarify containment; document containment	Contrast: containment should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify containment and the evidence that supports it.
ransomware	In cybersecurity, ransomware is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to communicate urgency without speculation.	clarify ransomware; document ransomware	Contrast: ransomware should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify ransomware and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
forensics	In cybersecurity, forensics is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to communicate urgency without speculation.	clarify forensics; document forensics	Contrast: forensics should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify forensics and the evidence that supports it.

Vulnerability Management

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
CVE	Common Vulnerabilities and Exposures identifier used to reference a publicly known cybersecurity vulnerability.	triage the CVE; patch the CVE	Contrast: A CVE identifies a known vulnerability; its identifier alone does not show whether a particular system is exposed. Example: First confirm whether the CVE affects the deployed version before scheduling the patch.
CVSS	Common Vulnerability Scoring System, a standardized method for expressing the severity and characteristics of a vulnerability.	review the CVSS score; contextualize CVSS	Contrast: CVSS expresses vulnerability severity, but it does not replace local exploitability and business-impact analysis. Example: The team will contextualize the CVSS score with internet exposure and compensating controls.
exploitability	In cybersecurity, exploitability is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to prioritize vulnerabilities beyond CVSS alone.	clarify exploitability; document exploitability	Contrast: exploitability should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify exploitability and the evidence that supports it.
compensating control	In cybersecurity, compensating control is a repeatable control mechanism used to prevent, detect, or confirm conditions before work proceeds. Use it when teams need to prioritize vulnerabilities beyond CVSS alone.	clarify compensating control; document compensating control	Contrast: compensating control should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify compensating control and the evidence that supports it.

Identity, Access, and Least Privilege

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
IAM	In cybersecurity, IAM is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to push back on excessive access requests.	clarify IAM; document IAM	Contrast: IAM should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify IAM and the evidence that supports it.
least privilege	In cybersecurity, least privilege is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to push back on excessive access requests.	clarify least privilege; document least privilege	Contrast: least privilege should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify least privilege and the evidence that supports it.
MFA	In cybersecurity, MFA is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to push back on excessive access requests.	clarify MFA; document MFA	Contrast: MFA should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify MFA and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
RBAC	In cybersecurity, RBAC is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to push back on excessive access requests.	clarify RBAC; document RBAC	Contrast: RBAC should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify RBAC and the evidence that supports it.

Threat Modeling and Secure Design

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
threat model	In cybersecurity, threat model is a condition or event that can create harm, loss, noncompliance, delay, or unacceptable performance. Use it when teams need to discuss security risk early in design.	assess threat model; mitigate threat model	Contrast: threat model identifies a possible or current exposure; it is not the same as accepting that exposure. Example: We need to assess threat model, name the owner, and agree on the trigger for escalation.
attack surface	Set of systems, interfaces, identities, and entry points an attacker could attempt to exploit.	reduce attack surface; map the attack surface	Contrast: Attack surface is the set of possible entry points for compromise, not evidence that an attack has occurred. Example: The security team is mapping the attack surface before exposing the new API.
trust boundary	In cybersecurity, trust boundary is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss security risk early in design.	clarify trust boundary; document trust boundary	Contrast: trust boundary should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify trust boundary and the evidence that supports it.
abuse case	In cybersecurity, abuse case is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss security risk early in design.	clarify abuse case; document abuse case	Contrast: abuse case should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify abuse case and the evidence that supports it.

Governance, Risk, and Compliance

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
control	A process, approval, check, or technical safeguard designed to reduce risk.	clarify control; document control	Contrast: control should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify control and the evidence that supports it.
audit evidence	In cybersecurity, audit evidence is a structured examination of evidence, process, or results used to reach a defensible conclusion. Use it when teams need to translate control gaps into business risk.	conduct a audit evidence; document the audit evidence	Contrast: audit evidence is a structured examination of evidence; it is not a conclusion reached before the evidence is checked. Example: The team will conduct a audit evidence before it recommends a corrective action.
risk acceptance	In cybersecurity, risk acceptance is a condition or event that can create harm, loss, noncompliance, delay, or unacceptable performance. Use it when teams need to translate control gaps into business risk.	assess risk acceptance; mitigate risk acceptance	Contrast: risk acceptance identifies a possible or current exposure; it is not the same as accepting that exposure. Example: We need to assess risk acceptance, name the owner, and agree on the trigger for escalation.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
remediation	In cybersecurity, remediation is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to translate control gaps into business risk.	clarify remediation; document remediation	Contrast: remediation should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify remediation and the evidence that supports it.

Security Awareness and Phishing

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
phishing	In cybersecurity, phishing is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to coach users without shaming them.	clarify phishing; document phishing	Contrast: phishing should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify phishing and the evidence that supports it.
social engineering	In cybersecurity, social engineering is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to coach users without shaming them.	clarify social engineering; document social engineering	Contrast: social engineering should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify social engineering and the evidence that supports it.
reporting culture	In cybersecurity, reporting culture is a workplace communication artifact that records facts, interpretation, and the decision or action requested. Use it when teams need to coach users without shaming them.	prepare a reporting culture; circulate the reporting culture	Contrast: reporting culture is a reviewable communication artifact, not an undocumented verbal assurance. Example: The reporting culture should state the evidence, caveat, decision owner, and next action.
security awareness	In cybersecurity, security awareness is a performance or governance dimension that must be protected through defined evidence, thresholds, and accountability. Use it when teams need to coach users without shaming them.	clarify security awareness; document security awareness	Contrast: security awareness should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify security awareness and the evidence that supports it.

Executive Risk Briefings

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
residual risk	In cybersecurity, residual risk is a condition or event that can create harm, loss, noncompliance, delay, or unacceptable performance. Use it when teams need to explain cyber risk in decision language.	assess residual risk; mitigate residual risk	Contrast: residual risk identifies a possible or current exposure; it is not the same as accepting that exposure. Example: We need to assess residual risk, name the owner, and agree on the trigger for escalation.
threat actor	In cybersecurity, threat actor is a condition or event that can create harm, loss, noncompliance, delay, or unacceptable performance. Use it when teams need to explain cyber risk in decision language.	assess threat actor; mitigate threat actor	Contrast: threat actor identifies a possible or current exposure; it is not the same as accepting that exposure. Example: We need to assess threat actor, name the owner, and agree on the trigger for escalation.
maturity	In cybersecurity, maturity is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to explain cyber risk in decision language.	clarify maturity; document maturity	Contrast: maturity should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify maturity and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
investment ask	In cybersecurity, investment ask is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to explain cyber risk in decision language.	clarify investment ask; document investment ask	Contrast: investment ask should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify investment ask and the evidence that supports it.

Industry-Specific Meeting Moves

Situation	Useful language
Security Triage and Alert Investigation	Before we commit, I want to confirm SIEM, alert, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If privilege, behavior, context, and evidence need review., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Incident Response and Containment	Before we commit, I want to confirm incident, containment, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If scope, containment, evidence preservation, communications, and legal review matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Vulnerability Management	Before we commit, I want to confirm CVE, CVSS, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If exploitability, exposure, asset criticality, compensating controls, and downtime must be balanced., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Identity, Access, and Least Privilege	Before we commit, I want to confirm IAM, least privilege, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If least privilege, approval, logging, and time-bound access are required., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Threat Modeling and Secure Design	Before we commit, I want to confirm threat model, attack surface, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If abuse cases, data flows, trust boundaries, and mitigations need design-time attention., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Governance, Risk, and Compliance	Before we commit, I want to confirm control, audit evidence, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If control design, evidence, ownership, remediation, and risk acceptance need clarity., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Security Awareness and Phishing	Before we commit, I want to confirm phishing, social engineering, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If behavior, training, reporting culture, and technical controls all matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Executive Risk Briefings	Before we commit, I want to confirm residual risk, threat actor, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If residual risk, threat landscape, controls, investment, and response readiness require nuance., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.

High-pressure pushback frames

- I understand the urgency. The risk is that we move faster than the evidence or process supports.
- I am not blocking the goal. I am naming the condition we need before the decision is safe and credible.
- If we accept this risk, we should name the owner, document the assumption, and define the trigger for escalation.
- That may be possible, but not under the current scope, timeline, or approval path.
- Let's separate what we know, what we assume, and what still needs confirmation.

Contrast Pairs

Do not confuse	Useful distinction
SIEM vs privileged account	In security triage and alert investigation, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.

Do not confuse	Useful distinction
incident vs forensics	In incident response and containment, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
CVE vs compensating control	In vulnerability management, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
IAM vs RBAC	In identity, access, and least privilege, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
threat model vs abuse case	In threat modeling and secure design, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
control vs remediation	In governance, risk, and compliance, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
phishing vs security awareness	In security awareness and phishing, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
residual risk vs investment ask	In executive risk briefings, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.